



MY CONSCIENCE IS CAPTIVE TO THE WORD OF GOD

MARTIN LUTHER'S 95 THESES (1517)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Reformation and Counter-Reformation

BEFORE

1379 English reformer John Wycliffe criticizes church practices in *De Ecclesia*.

1415 Czech reformer Jan Hus is burned at the stake.

1512 During a stay in Rome, Martin Luther's eyes are opened to church corruption.

AFTER

1520 Lutheran services are held regularly in Copenhagen.

1534 Henry VIII of England breaks from Rome and becomes head of the church in England.

1536 John Calvin begins his church reforms in Switzerland.

1545–1563 The Council of Trent reaffirms Catholic doctrines, beginning the Counter-Reformation movement.

In the fall of 1517, Martin Luther, a monk and teacher of theology at the University of Wittenberg in Germany, set off a chain reaction that would transform Europe. Deeply concerned by

“Injury is done to the Word of God when, in the same sermon, an equal or larger amount of time is devoted to indulgences than to the Word.”

Martin Luther, 1517 ”

what he saw as corrupt practices in the Catholic Church, he wrote a series of 95 theses—arguments—against them, which he then circulated within the university. According to some reports, he also nailed them to the door of the Castle Church in Wittenberg. The theses were soon published more widely, prompting Pope Leo X to charge Luther with heresy. Luther responded by breaking with the Catholic faith, so initiating the Reformation—the rise of churches based on reformed practices, and a focus on scripture rather than on priestly authority. Because of the churches' origin in protests against Catholic practices and beliefs, they became known as Protestant churches.

Spread of the Reformation

Luther was not alone in seeking religious reform. Swiss preacher Ulrich Zwingli (1484–1531) led a Protestant church based in Zurich, and Frenchman John Calvin broke from the Catholic church in around 1530. Forced to flee France, he went to